

EFFECTIVENESS OF PERSON-CENTERED THERAPY

A Term Paper

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Paper I



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Abstract

Person-centered therapy also known as client-centered was first introduced by Carl Rogers. It is talk therapy where a counselor is just a medium to assist clients to their full potential. Clients themselves are capable of self-understanding, altering their self-concepts, attitudes, and self-directed behaviors and the counselors just help to put these capabilities on track through different psychological attitudes. The objective of this study is to find out the effectiveness of client-or person-centered therapy. The information and data used to find out the effectiveness of client-or person-centered therapy was obtained from few types of research, articles on this topic and was found to be effective in different areas of common mental health problems. Though PCT is effective in different counseling sessions, combined with other therapies is recommended.

Introduction

There are different psychotherapies that are being practiced in counseling sessions every day all over the world. Each individual counselor and therapist practices different therapies into their sessions with their clients depending upon the needs and situation of clients. As stated by Corey (2013) “no single model of therapies can explain all the aspects of human experience”. However, a counselor or therapist will “adapt a counseling style from their own personality” (Corey, 2013, p. 5). There are five broad categories of psychotherapy, psychoanalysis and psychodynamic therapies, behavior therapy, cognitive therapy, humanistic therapy, and holistic therapy. Out of which humanistic therapy consists of two popular techniques, gestalt therapy, and client-or person-centered therapy (Buchwald, 2019).

Person-centered therapy also known as client-centered therapy was first introduced by Carl Rogers. He strongly believed that in order to improve the condition of a client, the therapist

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should be warm, genuine, and understanding. Rogers (1980, p.115-117) stated that "It is that the individual has within himself or herself vast resources for self-understanding, for altering his or her self-concept, attitudes and self-directed behavior and that these resources can be tapped if only a definable climate of facilitative psychological attitudes can be provided". He gave three attributes that will help clients to be self-directed towards what they are capable of.

This paper tends to find out the effectiveness of client-or person-centered therapy. The information and data used to find out the effectiveness of client-or person-centered therapy was obtained from few types of research, articles on this topic.

Person-centered therapy as defined by the Encyclopedia of Mental Disorders (2018) is an approach to counseling and psychotherapy that places much of the responsibility for the treatment process on the client, with the therapist taking a non-directive role. According to Psychology Today (n.d.), Person-centered therapy is talk therapy wherein the client does most of the talking. The counselor or therapist will not judge or try to interpret what the client says but may restate the client's words in an attempt to fully understand their thoughts and feelings. Carl Rogers's professional experience taught him that when a person finds a way to one's core, one finds trust and a positive center. There might occur certain positive changes in clients when a counselor or therapist is real, supporting, caring, understanding, and non-judgmental. Person-centered therapies resist formal diagnoses, goal-setting, and clearly defined strategies because they believe that doing so dehumanizes the client (Cooper, McLeod, 2010) reducing them from a person seeking wholeness to a problem that needs to be solved. There is "a particular emphasis on the fact that each human being is distinctive, irreplaceable, and unexchangeable," (Cooper,

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McLeod, 2010), and that each individual being different constrain a much more fluid therapeutic approach to treatment. Person-centered therapy, on the other hand, seeks to meet the individual where they are and passively inspire them to become the person they want to be.

There are three attributes given by Rogers that creates a growth developing environment where clients can move ahead and achieve what they are capable of achieving. Those attributes are, Congruence (Genuineness, or Realness), Unconditional Positive Regard (Acceptance and Caring), and Accurate Empathic Understanding (an ability to deeply understand and acknowledge the values, motivation, knowledge, or skills of another person). The purpose of these attributes is, simply, to earn the trust of the client, that they will become less defensive and more comfortable to open themselves and their world and helps a session to be more constructive.

- **Congruence (Genuineness, or Realness):** - Congruence means counselors are real, they are truthful, authentic, and integrated during sessions. Their internal and external expressions of that experience are similar. Counselors and therapists have to share their feelings, thoughts, reactions, attitude honestly. This helps in building trust between counselor and client and makes a session fruitful for the client.
- **Unconditional Positive Regard (Acceptance and Caring):** - The second attribute is about unconditional positive regard where the counselors and therapist must accept the client for who they are and develop deep and genuine care without any judgments. Rogers believed that for people to grow and fulfill their potential it is important that they are valued as themselves. According to Rogers's (1977) research, "the greater the degree of caring, prizing, accepting, and valuing of the client in a non-possessive way, the greater the chance that therapy will be successful". According to research, "creating an

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environment of unconditional positive regard, clients feel comfortable to express his/her true emotions without any fear of rejection” (Cherry, 2020).

- **Empathic Understanding:** - Empathy is the ability of counselor and therapist to understand the feelings and experiences of the client sensitively and accurately as they are expressed in the moment-to-moment interaction during the session. It is like standing in the client’s shoes, i.e., seeing or understanding things from the client’s position or perspective and sensing the client’s feelings as if they were his/her own without becoming lost in those feelings. Empathy is an essential part of a successful session.

Gibbard, Hanley (2008) conducted a routine-based study of A five-year evaluation of the effectiveness of person-centered counseling in routine clinical practice in primary care. In this study, the Core Outcome Measure (CORE-OM) was administered at the referral and at the beginning and end of therapy. On the basis of this study, person-centered therapy is effective for clients with common mental health problems, such as anxiety and depression. Effectiveness is not limited to individuals with mild to moderate symptoms of recent onset but extends to people with moderate to severe symptoms of longer duration.

Sa’ad FM et al. (2014) conducted a study on the effectiveness of person-centered therapy and cognitive psychology ad-Din group counseling on self-concept, depression, and resilience of pregnant out-of-wedlock teenagers. In this study, 55 pregnant out-of-wedlock teenagers were involved. They were classed into two treatment groups and one control group. To assess self-concept, depression, and resilience of pregnant out-of-wedlock teenagers, the Multidimensional Self-Concept Scale (MSCS), Beck Depression Inventory (BDI), and Adolescent Resiliency Attitude Scale (ARAS) were used. All treatment groups received group counseling sessions for 7

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consecutive weeks, once each week. Data were analyzed using descriptive analysis, ANOVA, MANCOVA, and Tuckey Post Hoc with a significant level of .01 and .05. They found that the Person-centered group and Cognitive Psychology Ad-Din group counseling showed significant reduction (pre-test to post-test) on depression, enhancing self-concept and resilience of pregnant out-of-wedlock teenagers.

Jones (2020) performed research on “Is person-centered counseling effective when assisting young people who have experienced bullying in schools?” In this research, Jones contacted four research participants and conducted research on the individuals who left the school because of childhood bullying. The individuals went through person-centered therapy to overcome the issues caused by bullying. The participants were interviewed with pre-decided questions. Finally, the research was concluded and most people found the PCT very useful and few found it not useful.

Conclusion and Recommendation

Although there are many therapies, different counselors practice different therapies as per their understanding and knowledge in that particular area. There is no any single therapy which can be effective to understand human behavior. But still some research and studies show that person centered therapy alone have been effective in different areas such as for clients with common mental health problems such as anxiety and depression, enhancing self-concept and resilience of pregnant out-of-wedlock teenagers, and childhood bullying. So, the data from previous studies clearly show the effectiveness of person-centered therapy in different areas.

Though PCT is effective in different counselling sessions, combination with other therapies is recommended.

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